

Public Questions and Mayor's Responses

West of England Combined Authority Committee and West of England Joint Committee, Friday 05 March 2026

Question 1 – Andrew Lynch

In January this year I asked you and your chief executive to commit to supplying monthly diaries and details of expenses, costs and gifts and hospitality, as well as an organisation chart for senior roles at this growing authority.

You said you were happy to publish a monthly list of meetings, but five months later and more than a year into your mayoralty you still have yet to do so. You said you had not claimed expenses but you have not declared any travel or accommodation costs. The request for the chief executive has just been ignored, which does raise doubts about the point of raising questions.

No organisational chart has been “developed”.

You said that officers were required to declare gifts and hospitality, although one might infer from your response that this has not been done. And since January no such records have been declared publicly to the audit committee.

In March I repeated my request to provide “all monthly diaries, (directly or indirectly paid) costs of travel, accommodation and gifts/hospitality records for yourself, the chief executive and the deputy mayor from May 1, 2025”.

At that point, you said you were reconsidering “the security implications of such arrangements, as well as working to understand the approach of and precedent set by other regional mayors”.

Now it's June. And we have another deputy mayor being paid for we don't know what. Can you please tell me what has come of all this? This a litmus test of the authority's commitment to transparency and value for money.

Mayor's Response

I understand that officers' declarations of gifts/hospitality are recorded by the combined authority and will in future be reported to the Audit Committee. The equivalent registers for Members are already published on the combined authority's website, where the 'senior team' page of website is due to be updated to include details of the areas that directors cover.

Following events in March, the authority has considered the security implications of publishing my diary. Officers have reviewed and will follow the established precedent set by other regional mayors.

Legislation requires me to appoint a statutory Deputy Mayor and I have done so on a rotating basis. The Independent Remuneration Panel's report included a role description when setting the allowance for that position in October.

Question 2 – Melissa Blackburn

I am writing to you as the CEO of Lockleaze Neighbourhood Trust, the Community Hub for Lockleaze in North Bristol. You will know that Lockleaze is a community of 14,000 people stretching from Filton Avenue up to Cheswick Village and down to IKEA. We are a resilient community with some challenges around health, housing and hardship and sadly, around transport - particularly our local bus service.

I am writing to ask in the strongest terms and on behalf of our community, why the 73 bus service has been withdrawn from Lockleaze.

You will have received similar concerns from David Wilcox our Local Councillor, and our MP Damian Egan will have also written to you.

At the top and middle of Lockleaze, the only bus services we have are the 24, 72 and the 73 - we have very few services as it is. The removal of the 73 means that it is now very difficult to get a direct bus into the centre of Bristol. I would suggest the withdrawal of this bus service is serious loss to our community and will contribute to community isolation and hardship. This is a serious concern for us as the community anchor organisation.

My understanding is there were three issues affecting this service:

- **Usage** - We know this service is well used, as the bus stop is right by our Community Hub building. This service is the only direct service into town via Broadmead as the 72 goes round the houses via Cotham. Local people need direct routes into the centre for work and play. My understanding is that this was seen as an underused service, but I would politely suggest you re-survey.
- **Scheduling** - Ask anyone in Lockleaze and they will tell you that the 72 and 73 bus often arrive within minutes of each other, with another hour to wait before the next service. Sorting out the scheduling issue would ideally have been addressed before cancelling the service.

- **Consultation** - We did not get a heads up about the transport survey that WECA did recently. It is really important that the community have their say in Lockleaze as I believe they would not support the cutting of our bus services.

Please urgently address this serious issue and please request an answer from WECA Transport and First Bus. We expect this bus service to be reinstated forthwith.

Mayor's Response

The majority of bus services in the West of England area are operated on a commercial basis, which gives them the ability to amend and withdraw the service for commercial reasons without consulting the combined authority. I asked the relevant officers to seek clarification from First Bus on why this service was withdrawn. They have been informed that First's removal of the 73 was instigated to better utilise their new depot south of Keynsham and to reduce duplication, with the 24 and 72 still serving the Lockleaze area. I have asked the team to closely monitor the impact of these changes.

Meanwhile, work is underway to allow us to take more control of our bus services, as every resident deserves a network they can trust to get them around and access everything our region has to offer. We are currently looking at a number of options to reform our buses, including different franchising models.

Listening to residents is a key part of our wider work on buses, which is why we recently asked people to shape a new Bus Plan for the region through the Next Stop, Better Buses consultation. We were pleased to receive thousands of responses from across the region but, to further maximise the reach of future consultations and engagement, I have asked the relevant officers to review and expand the list of local organisations who are notified.

Question 3 – Rosa Kell

What discussion have taken place

With the west of England mayoral combined transport Authority and North Somerset council over the new

about the bus service Tenders starting 26th july 2026

Passengers groups are very concerned about connectivity from Somerset in Bristol city centre and Southmead hospital bus station and cribbs causeway bus station.

Service x91 Bristol city centre, Bristol Temple meads station, south Bristol to

Chew stoke Chew magna Bishop Sutton for work journeys and school journeys to Chew valley school from south Bristol.

Open proposals to extend this service to Whitecroft, Farmborough. Timsbury and Bath spa bus and coach station.

Merged with bus service 99 Chew valley local service.

Service x10 Southmead hospital bus station, Cribbs causeway bus station Portishead Clevedon Dial Hill and Yatton Railway station.

Possible to Wrington

We very concerned about the loss of the link to Bristol Southmead hospital bus station and Bristol cribbs causeway bus station from North Somerset.

Service Bristol to Winsford. P1

Services k 1 keynsham Town service with connection from Bristol city centre to Arnos vale Bristlington keynsham service 43 .

Along with services 25 south Bristol to lockleaze uwe bus and coach station via Bristol city centre st Paul's st werburgess.

We are very concerned about these services.

and proposals from 376 ,375 ,374 Bristol bus and coach station Bristol Temple meads, Totterdown ,Knowle Hengrove Whitchurch , Pensford Clutton Farringdon Gurney Chewton Mendip Wells bus and coach station and Glastonbury and street to Yeovil bus and coach station 376 and service 375 Bridgwater bus and coach station.

374 to Bridgwater bus and coach station

With the Electricitification of the city Region bus network with the bus and coach Depots and in weston super mare Somerset, Bath Somerset Bristol Lawrence hill Electricitification under construction and Bristol Hengrove completed.

What discussion are going with the west of England mayoral combined transport Authority and North Somerset and Banes and Somerset council about the Electricitification of keynsham and Wells bus Depots and stagecoach Red and white services Depot in Patchway Bristol

Which are Depots for service in south Bristol, Bristol and Bath .

The UK Government Department for Transport deadline is for target for Electrification by 2030 2035 .

This will improved clean Air Quality in Bristol and improve the Carbon footprint.

Wells Depot services operate 171 173 174 from Bath spa bus and coach station to Peasdown st john, Radstock Westfield midsomer Norton paulton Shepton mallet Wells bus and coach and via 173 Chilcompton

So Wells is a Depot that services the west of England mayoral combined transport Authority and North Somerset council on service 126 weston super mare bus and coach station to wells Bus and coach station via cheddar.

Keynsham service 43 42 Kingswood to Bristol city centre to Bristol Temple meads station, Arnos vale Bristlington keynsham and keynsham bus Depot

43 needs to go around the estate in the Evenings

Service 17 keynsham bus Depot keynsham Town centre, keynsham Railway station, Hanham Kingswood Hilfields Staple Hill Fishponds Eastville park Ashley Down station Southmead hospital bus station.

Buses at Wells and keynsham bus Depot are currently 14 years old .

We are also very concerned about equalities training on stagecoach South West with a wheelchair passengers being asked to climb up the stairs on the coach and not being able to use the accessible seats on Falcon coaches services Scottish City link megabus operated by Stagecoach South west.

On Bristol Bond Street, Bristol Airport Churchill East Brent Bridgwater Taunton Wellington Cullompton Exeter Newton Abbot and Plymouth coach station.

The incident happened between Bristol Airport and Wellington.

What discussion have the mayor and the west of England mayoral combined transport Authority and North Somerset council had about equalities training with stagecoach Group and Rmt bus drivers union .

When is bus forum being set up North Somerset council have a meeting at the campus in worle Weston super mare Somerset.

But their no date for a west of England mayoral combined Authority forum

Or setting up an access panel.

Mayor's Response

We have secured significant funding to date for bus improvements, including our new green buses and electrification, and will continue working to deliver our wider Transport Vision.

The incident that you reference was unacceptable. When we were alerted to that case, I directed the relevant officers to raise it directly with the bus operator to ensure that this does not happen again.

I understand that these questions have already been answered by the authority's officers at Monday's meeting, but appreciate you bringing them to my attention.

Question 4 – Rosa Kell

With Somerset unitary Council With Bridgwater Town having put in a expression of interest to Franchise Somerset bus network but as that network is linked to North Somerset council, Banes and Bristol .

What discussion are not going with the west of England mayoral combined transport Authority and North Somerset council to Franchise the bus network.

Simon Lightwood mp buses and coaches minster. Has asked Somerset council to apply to the Department to Franchise the bus network

Rosa kell Somerset catch the bus campaign and Somerset bus partnership.

Mayor's Response

We are committed to reforming our buses and improving services for passengers.

We are looking carefully at all of the options for how to take greater control of our buses, with several different operating/funding models on the table, including franchising models.

More immediately, we're already working to quickly improve our bus network, as we secure more investment and make the most of devolution to catch up with other regions. Over 250 new green buses will be on our streets by the end of this year, with four electric depots, alongside offers like Kids Go Free over the school holidays – with our scheme inspiring a £100 million national equivalent this August.

We have recently asked people across the region to have their say more generally on our buses to help shape our developing Bus Plan as part of a transport network that people can trust, and are grateful to the thousands of people who shared their views.

Question 5 – Stuart Phelps

Youth Guarantee Trailblazer Procurement Strategy

"How will the Combined Authority structure its upcoming Youth Guarantee Trailblazer procurement to ensure that employment and skills funding is devolved directly to embedded, neighbourhood-level community organisations within high-deprivation wards like Easton and Lawrence Hill, rather than being consolidated into top-down, tier-1 commercial contracts?"

Mayor's Response

In the second year of the Youth Guarantee, we are keen to build on the successes of its pilot year. Some 300 young people were engaged during that time across the West of England, working through local councils and partners.

Spurred on by the recent Milburn Review and guided by our new Skills Strategy, we are excited to be working with a range of organisations from the Voluntary, Community and Social Enterprise sector working across the region through the Mayor's Youth Guarantee Fund. As embedded local organisations, they have the best chance of reaching the young people who need our support. A grant funding process has taken place with recipients including organisations operating in Easton and Lawrence Hill.

Over 1,000 more young people in the West will be able to access the Youth Guarantee Trailblazer scheme, and I hope supported into work and training, following an additional £2 million investment in the programme from the combined authority.

Question 6 – Stuart Phelps

"In light of the landmark Milburn Report's findings that youth economic inactivity is increasingly driven by deep structural detachment and mental distress rather than a simple lack of job vacancies, what specific long-term sustainability metrics will the Combined Authority embed into its skills contracts to prevent outside providers from claiming short-term placement outcomes without achieving genuine, long-term career progression for inner-city youth?"

Mayor's Response

The Milburn Review underlines the scale of the challenge and the need to invest in the right systems, support and opportunities for young people, with clearer pathways into work and hope for the future. Our new Skills Strategy, set to be approved at Friday's

meeting, includes an ambition for the region to become the country's first NEET Zero region.

Where the combined authority funds provision, we are strengthening outcomes commissioning by building longer-term progression measures into funded activity, aligned to the Outcomes Framework. This means moving beyond short-term placement reporting and focusing on sustained engagement, progression into education, employment or training, and longer-term career pathways. Current Youth Guarantee delivery is helping us to test this through staged support, including identification, personalised support, employer brokerage, progression planning and follow-up.

We are looking to work with DWP to encourage longer-term outcome measures, including sustained employment, progression in learning, apprenticeship starts, retention in work, and movement towards good-quality employment. Where appropriate, Youth Guarantee participants can also progress onto Connect to Work for a further 12 months of additional support.

Question 7 – Matt Sanders

SBLN Through Traffic: What data was submitted to WECA?

[Please note that I submitted this first question for Monday's Overview and Scrutiny Committee, but the Officer Response was the same generic reply issued to other participants, and contained no reply to the specific questions which I asked. I trust this will not happen a second time, as it would show WECA in a very poor light, and cause readers to make all sorts of negative assumptions...]

*** THE DEFINITION ***

The Department for Transport's "**Statutory Guidance for Implementing Low Traffic Neighbourhoods**" has this DEFINITION:

"An area-wide traffic management scheme aimed at reducing or removing through traffic from residential areas, put in place using traffic signed restrictions or physical measures such as planters or bollards."

So — in order to QUALIFY as a "Low Traffic Neighbourhood" — a scheme MUST include MODAL FILTERS — with the express intention being to eliminate "through traffic."

*** THE FUNDING ***

Bristol City Council's **SBLN webpages ("Residential Streets")** notes:

“To secure UK Government funding for this project from the West of England Mayoral Combined Authority, our designs must include these types of measures.”

So — in order to secure funding — the SBLN has to include modal filters.

Without them, there is no money for anything at all.

*** THE DOWNSIDE ***

The downside of modal filters, is that they cause massive disruption for residents, carers, tradesmen, taxis, utilities and deliveries — with longer journeys, social isolation, and compromised emergency services, etc.

So — in order to JUSTIFY these unwanted side effects — there must be a significant PROVEN issue with through traffic.

*** THE JUSTIFICATION ***

Sure enough, the SBLN proposals included 12 modal filters in the Southville Zone.

And in order to JUSTIFY them, the **Council Website (“Phase 1 Neighbourhoods: Southville”)** — claims:

“Traffic data show that high numbers of vehicles from outside the area use residential streets in Southville as a cut-through to other destinations.”

But what “Traffic Data” proves this claim...?

*** THE EVIDENCE ***

Despite being asked on countless occasions, to provide the specific “Traffic Data” which confirmed “High Numbers”, the Council failed to comply.

And that is despite it being in their interest to do so, as any compelling “Traffic Data” would of course justify the scheme.

In June 2024, 25 ANPR cameras were used throughout the SBLN region, to gather origin-destination data for thousands of vehicles. But sadly none of them were placed in the Southville Zone, or at its main entrances or exits.

So no useful data was gathered, to demonstrate ANY quantity of through traffic in the Southville Zone, let alone “High Numbers”.

*** THE ADDITIONAL DATA ***

On 29th April 2026, after these issues received public attention on the websites of Bristol Live and Bristol 24/7, and the BBC recorded a film for Politics West, the **Council Website (“Key Dates and Reports”)** published two additional documents, which had not previously been revealed.

One was a **“Through Traffic Analysis”** — produced by Arup, seventeen months earlier, in **November 2024**.

The other was a **“Through Traffic Interactive Map”** utilising telematics data from “The Floow” — produced nine months earlier, in **July 2025**.

If the Council genuinely believed in the credibility of these documents, it is curious that they chose not to mention them, in response to the many public forum requests to the Transport Committee and Full Council, that they state which specific “Traffic Data” confirmed “High Numbers” of vehicles cutting through Southville.

*** THE DRAFT BUSINESS CASE ***

The **“Key Dates and Reports” webpage** also indicates that, in June 2025, a **“Draft Business Case”** was prepared, in order to gain development funding for the SBLN, from WECA.

As outlined above, the justification for a Low Traffic Neighbourhood hinges upon there being a proven existing problem with excessive quantities of “through traffic.”

Therefore, to gain this development funding, the Council must surely have presented WECA with statistics to demonstrate this problem.

Therefore, please now state which specific statistics, from which sources, were presented to WECA, to demonstrate the severity of the alleged issue with “through traffic”.

Or, if no specific statistics were presented, then please confirm that this was the case.

*** THE GENERIC OFFICER RESPONSE ***

So the text above was my **Public Forum Question** to WECA’s recent **Overview and Scrutiny Committee**, of 1st June 2026.

The following text was the **Officer Response**:

Bristol City Council has consulted on South Bristol Liveable Neighbourhoods (SBLN) and it is now for them to refine proposals, considering public feedback and data collected, and then submit a business case bid to the regional authority for us to assess in detail (including the relevant data). We expect revised proposals to be published by the council by the summer.

Similarly it will be for the council to submit a business case for East Bristol Liveable Neighbourhood (EBLN) for the combined authority to consider. In September, at the outset of the council’s consultation, the Mayor emphasised the importance of hearing local people’s voices and that feedback will be a key part of how the combined authority assesses this bid. You may have also seen, to that end, that the combined authority has commissioned a full independent review of the EBLN from outside the region, covering

engagement and consultation to installation and impact – with all the available data, which is due to report back in the coming weeks.

*** NO RELEVANT RESPONSE ***

Identical text was also published, in response to two other parties who submitted different Questions about the SBLN. But as all readers can see, the second paragraph was about the EBLN, so not relevant to my question about the SBLN.

And while the first paragraph was about the SBLN, it only addressed the Council's current development of a future business case. But my Question was very clearly asking what specific data regarding "Through Traffic" was submitted to WECA last year, in order to secure development funding for the SBLN.

No relevant answer has been provided, despite it being very easy for officials to check last year's documents, and provide the requested information.

I do not know the reason, for this lack of candour.

So, like everybody else, I can only speculate...

*** SPECULATION ***

Perhaps BCC **did** submit some "Through Traffic" statistics — which played a part in WECA's decision to grant development funding — but those statistics have since been discredited — so it would cause considerable embarrassment all round, to now state what they were...?

Or perhaps — despite the entire rationale for a Low Traffic Neighbourhood being to address a serious issue with "Through Traffic" — BCC **did not** submit any statistics to demonstrate that such a problem existed — and WECA did not ask for any, before granting development funding — which could demonstrate a failure by both parties to perform due diligence...?

Perhaps both scenarios are paranoid delusions, and nothing untoward has happened...?

But the failure to answer my very simple Question will inevitably lead many readers to jump to these (and worse) conclusions...

*** CLEARING THE AIR ***

I cannot pretend to know what has happened behind the scenes, have no evidence of any wrongdoing, and am making no specific allegations.

But all parties must surely acknowledge that the lack of any relevant response to my very simple Question is hugely politically damaging.

limit. And it fosters suspicion and resentment in a community which already has serious concerns that unwanted draconian measures are being imposed upon them, against their will.

So — in order to clear the air — I trust that the Mayor will ensure that we all receive a straightforward, coherent, and non-generic Response to my clear Question:

Please state which specific statistics, from which sources, were presented by BCC to WECA in 2025, to demonstrate the severity of the alleged issue with “through traffic” in Southville.

Or, if no specific statistics were presented, then please confirm that this was the case.

Mayor’s Response

Further to my previous responses around the South Bristol Liveable Neighbourhoods proposals, I appreciate you bringing these questions to my attention.

I understand that officers responded on Monday to confirm that the combined authority will receive and consider and formally assess all of the relevant data (including traffic/through-traffic information) from the council once they have submitted their bid for funding.

In another question on Monday, officers provided the below response which may also be of interest:

“Bristol City Council is responsible for the development and design of any proposed project, including the collection and interpretation of local traffic data. The combined authority does not apply a single traffic threshold or specific level of through traffic that would automatically secure or prevent funding. Funding rules do not require the use of any specific traffic management measures. Proposed interventions are developed by the relevant highway authority. Schemes must also comply with national design standards and consider a range of other factors.”

Question 8 – Matt Sanders

Low Traffic Neighbourhood Funding Requirements

As noted in my first question:

*** THE LTN DEFINITION ***

The Department for Transport’s **“Statutory Guidance for Implementing Low Traffic Neighbourhoods”** has this DEFINITION:

"An area-wide traffic management scheme aimed at reducing or removing through traffic from residential areas, put in place using traffic signed restrictions or physical measures such as planters or bollards."

So — in order to QUALIFY as a "Low Traffic Neighbourhood" — it appears that a scheme MUST include MODAL FILTERS — with the express intention being to eliminate "through traffic."

*** BCC'S UNDERSTANDING ***

Bristol City Council's **SBLN webpages ("Residential Streets")** seems to confirm this interpretation:

"To secure UK Government funding for this project from the West of England Mayoral Combined Authority, our designs must include these types of measures."

So — in order to secure funding — it appears that BCC believes the SBLN has to include modal filters.

*** WECA'S UNDERSTANDING ***

However, in the Public Forum of Monday's **WECA Overview and Scrutiny Committee**, Helen Hughes asked a question which touched upon this issue, and the **Officer Response** included:

"Funding rules do not require the use of any specific traffic management measures."

But this could be read in two very different ways...

*** EITHER / OR... ***

EITHER:

As Helen's question specifically posited the notion that, (as per BCC's apparent understanding) in order to secure funding, a Liveable Neighbourhood *"must include modal filters"* — one could interpret this Officer Response as a denial of this requirement.

(Which suggests WECA and BCC have differing understandings of the "funding rules"...)

OR:

Alternatively, we could note that the DfT Definition of a Low Traffic Neighbourhood listed **three different examples** of modal filters:

1: "Traffic signed restrictions" — eg bus gates, or prohibitions of certain types of vehicles, which may be enforced with ANPR cameras;

2: "Planters" — eg wooden or plastic boxes, which may contain an assortment of weeds;

3: “Bollards” — eg metal poles which may (or may not) be removable by emergency services;

The DfT definition of an LTN does not specifically “require” any one of these options over the others.

But it does appear to “require” at least one of them.

* “... **ANY SPECIFIC...**” *

So, when officers wrote — “*Funding rules do not require the use of any specific traffic management measures*” — perhaps they were stating that:

a) *an LTN does not need to include **any** type of modal filter...*

Or perhaps they were only stating that:

b) *an LTN does not need to include any **specific** type of modal filter.*

* **SO MY QUESTION IS:** *

Please clearly state whether — if BCC’s proposals for the SBLN did not include ANY type of modal filter as described above — it would still qualify for funding...?

Mayor’s Response

Further to my previous answer, the combined authority does not prescribe specific traffic management measures. Once the council has submitted revised proposals and data, including specifying the definition of the scheme type, we will be able to consider any relevant further guidance from the Department for Transport.

Question 9 – Lucy Bell-Reeves

We write to you as a group of residents in Brislington who love our green spaces and care about decent homes that local people can afford being built. We have been campaigning to do what every major political party has promised to do - save Brislington Meadows.

We write with regards to the Nature Recovery Fund and the Hicks Gate Masterplan you are discussing this coming Friday on the 5th June.

On the 1st April, at Planning Committee B in Bristol City Council, the reserved matters to build on Brislington Meadows was discussed and voted against - it was deferred. On the 20th May, Councillors voted against the development again because many of the roads would not be adopted by the Highways Authority because they are too steep. They also don't meet Bristol's own golden criteria for accessibility. We were also shocked that the

biodiversity net gain condition was not brought to discussion at the planning committee as it was put in a separate application.

The developers, Keepmoat, already have another application in - put in 3 days before their planning permission ran out. We have heard they are also looking to appeal this decision that was made by our elected representatives.

But we believe you have an opportunity to prioritise green space for the community whilst also building homes and infrastructure.

We believe Brislington needs to keep as much of its green space as it possibly can for the benefit of the community. With this in mind, we write to you to request you look to use your Nature Recovery Fund and your close relationship with Homes England to buy Brislington Meadows for the community. This would go some way to allay concerns around the vanishing green spaces in our area - especially with the Hicks Gate Masterplan being proposed.

Losing such a large number of green fields (with public rights of way) to over 3,000 homes, next to an already incredibly congested A4, as well as Brislington Meadows, would mean a massive loss of green space for residents (almost 100 hectares). We are also hugely concerned that despite it coming out prominently in the consultation and Labour's aim of 50% social homes on green belt sites, there were no mentions of social or affordable housing in the Masterplan.

We would also flag, in the Masterplan, Brislington Meadows is marked as an 'open space' with trees and woodland on the map (page 582). If the development on Brislington Meadows does go ahead, this will not be the case. The only park in the area will be Victory Park, which is 7 hectares (compared with Brislington Meadows at 9.6 hectares and the Hicks Gate development, all on green fields, at 84 hectares). It is vital Brislington residents have access to green space and there is a joined up approach to decision making.

Our questions:

What assessment has been done on the amount of accessible green space that is being lost to Brislington residents if both Brislington Meadows and the Hicks Gate Masterplan goes ahead?

Mayor's Response

Nature is one of the things that makes the West of England so special, so I appreciate why you are raising this issue today. Nature is a thread running through our Growth Strategy and will also be an important part of our developing Spatial Development Strategy. Growth and nature do not need to conflict, something that we know and believe in the fastest-growing regional economy, which is also the natural home of new green

jobs, and the country's first new national forest in decades. The importance of this work will be further underlined in next week's State of Nature report.

Our new £5 million Nature Fund can make a significant difference at landscape-scale projects across the region already identified through our Local Nature Recovery Strategy. While I note that this sum is many times lower than the land value of Brislington Meadows, I sympathise with the concerns of residents and appreciate the work of Kerry McCarthy MP and local councillors.

Local councils are responsible for determining planning applications within their boundaries, and for developing their Local Plans. Brislington Meadows was allocated for housing within Bristol's 2014 Local Plan, while a new neighbourhood at Bath Road, Brislington (i.e. the Bristol element of Hicks Gate) was allocated within the new Local Plan submitted by Bristol in 2024.

Bath & North East Somerset are also considering potential development at Hicks Gate through their emerging Local Plan, which is due for submission later this year. The councils have considered a number of factors, including accessible green space, when developing these plans.

Question 10 – Lucy Bell-Reeves

Would the Committee agree to scope out a proposal to buy Brislington Meadows from Homes England as a way to create a nature rich habitat, suitable for BNG units, as a way to alleviate the loss of green space in Brislington if the Hicks Gate Masterplan goes ahead?

Mayor's Response

Further to my previous answer, as far as we are aware, Homes England has no intention of selling the Brislington Meadows site. I sympathise with the concerns of residents and appreciate the work of Kerry McCarthy MP and local councillors.

More widely, the Hicks Gate Masterplan aims to deliver a high-quality environment that is in harmony with its attractive landscape setting. It should incorporate a network of green connections, active travel routes and green space linking to the surrounding countryside.

A range of leisure and recreational facilities are expected to be provided, with green links for walking and cycling. This would connect local residents to amenities and enable them to be connected with nature.

Question 11 – Cllr Tim Rippington

HICKS GATE MASTERPLAN

It is good to see that a Masterplan for the Hicks Gate area is being developed, including a transport hub.

As a non-statutory Planning Framework, how can we ensure that the necessary facilities such as schools, medical facilities and a transport hub are actually delivered alongside the housing which will inevitably be built there?

Mayor's Response

I have spoken regularly about the importance of new homes being accompanied by the right infrastructure and services. The masterplan sets out to ensure a joined-up approach to infrastructure provision across local authority boundaries. This includes key social infrastructure such as the provision of new schools.

The key aims of the joint masterplan are to provide the evidence base to support Bristol and Bath & North East Somerset (B&NES) councils in determining applications for land parcels in this area and producing their respective Local Plans, if the B&NES Local Plan seeks to allocate land for development.

Once adopted, the Local Plans will provide the planning policy framework which this joint masterplan framework is intended to complement.

Question 12 – Cllr Tim Rippington

MASS TRANSIT ALONG THE A4

The WECA Transport Vision sets out a plan to deliver a first stage of Mass Transit within 5 years. The A4 corridor is the obvious place to do this – the demand is high and the Authority is already committed to spending millions of pounds of CRSTS funding on improving the corridor for public transport.

How can we ensure that the current plans for the corridor, which are at OBC stage, are complimentary to and an enabler for future mass transit rather than piecemeal improvements which will need to be replaced in a few years' time?

Mayor's Response

Current plans for the corridor under the Bristol to Bath Strategic Corridor project are being progressed and are approaching the full business case stage. Any decisions we

take on that scheme must be with the long-term future of the corridor in mind, and I have spoken about the need to consider key routes like the A4 as we develop mass transit options.

This is a position that seems to be supported by feedback from a number of recent stakeholder workshops about the second phase of delivering work on this corridor. Thank you for attending one of these sessions.

Our regional Transport Vision sets out a clear ambition for developing plans for and delivering mass transit in the West of England. We are actively undertaking the work required to move forward the technical and investment cases for mass transit. This includes looking at options for early deliverables.

Question 13 – Cllr Katja Hornchen

A4 CORRIDOR PROJECT – PHASE ONE DELIVERY

Phase I of the A4 Corridor Project, funded under CRSTS, promises to deliver some very significant improvements to infrastructure in Brislington, not least on Wick Road and Newbridge Road. Improved bus stops, traffic calming measures and improved walking, wheeling and cycling measures are all very welcome in an area which often sees ‘rat-running’ by those seeking to avoid congestion on the A4.

Residents have waited many years for these improvements to be delivered, however, they do not have a timescale for when this might happen.

Please can you confirm when work on this project will commence and when it must be completed by?

Mayor’s Response

As the project is funded through our City Region Sustainable Transport Settlement (CRSTS) programme, it is required to be under contract by March 2027 and completed by March 2029.

The Bristol to Bath A4 (Phase 1) scheme is currently progressing through the necessary design, approval and procurement stages. While it is not yet possible to confirm a construction start date for individual elements, the relevant officers advise that the entire anticipated construction period is approximately 18 months.

Question 14 – Cllr David Wilcox

Bus Services that serve Lockleaze Ward.

Lockleaze Ward is surrounded by arterial roads, including Filton Avenue, Muller Road, and, of course, the M32. These routes all have reasonably frequent bus services, but the central estate around Gainsborough Square has recently seen a significant reduction in services.

First Bus has withdrawn the frequent 73 service from UWE to the centre via Gainsborough Square, except for a single very early-morning service. This change poses a serious challenge for residents of Lockleaze Ward, where 24.3% of households lack a car. A reliable bus service was a key factor in attracting over 400 new families to housing developments around the square, such as Branwhite, Herkomer, and One Lockleaze.

A faster service than the 24, which is heavily delayed by traffic along the Stapleton Road Corridor, is needed. The priority bus route along the Gloucester Road provides excellent access to the city centre and to a main shopping street.

Can the Mayor please consider providing an alternative supported service, please?

Mayor's Response

The majority of bus services in the West of England area are operated on a commercial basis, which gives them the ability to amend and withdraw the service for commercial reasons without consulting the combined authority. I asked the relevant officers to seek clarification from First Bus on why this service was withdrawn. They have been informed that First's removal of the 73 was instigated to better utilise their new depot south of Keynsham and to reduce duplication, with the 24 and 72 still serving the Lockleaze area. I have asked the team to closely monitor the impact of these changes, and to explore options while working with operators through the Enhanced Partnership to look at opportunities to enhance services.

Meanwhile, work is underway to allow us to take more control of our bus services, as every resident deserves a network that they can trust to get them around and access everything our region has to offer. We are currently looking at a number of options to reform our buses, including different franchising models.

Listening to residents is a key part of our wider work on buses, which is why we recently asked people to shape a new Bus Plan for the region through the Next Stop, Better Buses consultation. We were pleased to receive thousands of responses from across the region for residents' voices to be part of developing the plan.

Question 15 – Cllr David Wilcox

Unfortunately, the 73 bus is not the only route experiencing severe cutbacks in Lockleaze. The 50 route connecting Lockleaze with Frenchay and the centre now runs even less frequently, and the 25 has been completely replaced by a mix of Eurocoaches and Stagecoach services. This route serves Lockleaze, St Werburghs, and St Pauls, providing their only remaining access to supermarkets in the city centre and Eastgate. This unreliable arrangement is programmed to last only until July, leaving residents desperately in need of reassurance that this service will continue beyond that date.

Can the Mayor provide reassurance to the communities along both the 50 and 25 routes that there will be continuity of service?

Mayor's Response

Further to my previous answer, commercial services are subject to change by the operators. They need to be registered with the combined authority, but this organisation is not consulted on changes.

A number of services which were due to end in April were extended to July to enable provision to be reviewed, options to be considered, and a full competitive tender to be completed. This included the number 25. The combined authority is undertaking that procurement exercise, which is a commercially confidential process until its conclusion.

We are also looking at what might be possible in line with feedback from the Bus Plan consultation and our ambitions set out in the Transport Vision.

Question 16 – Cllr Rob Bryher

Youth Guarantee

The Youth Guarantee is a test and learn project. Bristol focused the programme on wards the data shows us have the highest levels of young people who are NEET. It is now well established and successful in enabling young people to get back into learning, employment, or training. Funding is due to run out at the end of March '27.

Given the recent findings of the Milburn report can the Mayor commit to funds post March '27 to retain the learning, staff teams, employer engagement and commitment given to young people, their families and communities in wards such as Hartcliffe, Withywood and Hengrove beyond this date?

Mayor's Response

National funding for our regional Youth Guarantee Trailblazer is currently set to continue until March 2027. The government has not yet set out what further funding will be made available to continue established activity.

In the second year of the Youth Guarantee, we are keen to build on the successes of its pilot year. Some 300 young people were engaged during that time across the West of England, working through local councils and partners.

Spurred on by the recent Milburn Review and guided by our new Skills Strategy, we are excited to be working with a range of organisations from the Voluntary, Community and Social Enterprise sector working across the region through the Mayor's Youth Guarantee Fund. As embedded local organisations, they have the best chance of reaching the young people who need our support. A grant funding process has taken place with recipients including organisations operating across south Bristol.

We want our Youth Guarantee to reach even more people and through the new funding we anticipate that over 1,000 more young people in the West will be able to access the scheme, and I hope be supported into work and training.

The second part of the Milburn Review is expected to report later this year, with recommendations for future government funding. We will of course look at that closely.

Question 17 – Andy Soar

With nearly 2,000 children living in temporary accommodation in Bristol, why is there zero mention of social or affordable housing in the Hicks Gate masterplan?

Mayor's Response

Local councils' policies for affordable and social housing will usually be set via their Local Plans, rather than through masterplans such as this. The final breakdown of numbers for different types of units is agreed within individual planning applications.

Affordable and social housing are incredibly important, and I want to help unlock more new homes through the Brownfield Housing Fund – with our first £45 million recently secured.

Building more homes to help get more households, particularly children, out of temporary accommodation is a key priority for the region through our Growth Strategy and Child Poverty Action Plan. This is also a real driver for the Small Sites Aggregator national pathfinder that we are leading, which looks at how to use smaller parcels of council land to deliver around 1,000 new homes across 60 sites – including in Bristol.

Question 18 – Andy Soar

I hope we would all agree that access to green space is absolutely vital for the residents of Brislington. The Hicks Gate Masterplan would build over 84 hectares of green belt green fields which have public access. Brislington Meadows are 9.6 hectares. If both these green fields with public rights of way are sacrificed, this would leave the only local green field space - Victory Park - at 7 hectares. What are you doing to ensure Brislington Residents continue to have access to a decent amount of green space?

Mayor's Response

Nature is one of the things that makes the West of England so special, so I appreciate why you are raising this issue today. Nature is a thread running through our Growth Strategy and will also be an important part of our developing Spatial Development Strategy. Growth and nature do not need to conflict, something that we know and believe in the fastest-growing regional economy, which is also the natural home of new green jobs, and the country's first new national forest in decades. The importance of this work will be further underlined in next week's State of Nature report.

The Hicks Gate Masterplan aims to deliver a high-quality environment that is in harmony with its attractive landscape setting. It should incorporate a network of green connections, active travel routes and green space linking to the surrounding countryside.

A range of leisure and recreational facilities are expected to be provided, with green links for walking and cycling. This would connect local residents to amenities and enable them to be connected with nature.

On Brislington Meadows, I sympathise with the concerns of residents and appreciate the work of Kerry McCarthy MP and local councillors.

Question 19 – Tamsin Ashton

1

What are you doing to mitigate the loss of access to green space for existing and new residents? This is green belt land that is used daily and should be protected. With the potential loss of Brislington Meadows and these green fields, there is a huge risk that the local access to green space will be diminished with a detrimental impact on the health of local people, on top of the destruction of nature. Can brownfield sites and existing derelict buildings not be prioritised?

Mayor's Response

Nature is one of the things that makes the West of England so special, so I appreciate why you are raising this issue today. Nature is a thread running through our Growth Strategy and will also be an important part of our developing Spatial Development Strategy. Growth and nature do not need to conflict, something that we know and believe in the fastest-growing regional economy, which is also the natural home of new green jobs, and the country's first new national forest in decades. The importance of this work will be further underlined in next week's State of Nature report.

I agree on the importance of utilising brownfield sites, and recently secured our first funding allocation through the national Brownfield Housing Fund – with £45 million to help deliver new homes, including new affordable homes, on brownfield sites.

Our leadership role in the Small Sites Aggregator pathfinder will only add to these efforts to tackle the housing crisis. Through this national programme, which looks at how to use smaller parcels of council land, we aim to deliver around 1,000 new homes across 60 sites – including in Bristol.

On Brislington Meadows, I sympathise with the concerns of residents and appreciate the work of Kerry McCarthy MP and local councillors.

Question 20 – Tamsin Ashton

What are you doing to mitigate the increase in traffic and air pollution? Bath Road is already incredible congested, it simply cannot withstand such a big development. Many roads in the area already exceed the WHO limit for air pollution, how can it be appropriate to add to this on such a big scale?

Mayor's Response

Further to my previous answer, land allocation at Hicks Gate has been considered by Bristol and B&NES councils as part of their Local Plan development.

I am a real advocate for new homes being built alongside the right infrastructure and services. The Hicks Gate Masterplan acknowledges the additional transport demand that the proposed development could generate – with public transport and active travel as priorities, including any future move for the Park & Ride site, to manage traffic and improve air quality along the A4.

Investment to improve our transport network, including with 250 new green buses set to be serving the region by the end of the year, will soon make a difference to air quality. These new and retrofitted electric vehicles will be serving more routes around the region, including the X39 between Bristol and Bath.

Current plans for the corridor under the Bristol to Bath Strategic Corridor project are being progressed and are approaching the full business case stage. Any decisions we take on that scheme must be with the long-term future of the corridor in mind, and I have spoken about the need to consider key routes like the A4 as we develop mass transit options. This is a position that seems to be supported by feedback from a number of recent stakeholder workshops about the second phase of delivering work on this corridor.

Our regional Transport Vision sets out a clear ambition for developing plans for and delivering mass transit in the West of England. We are actively undertaking the work required to move forward the technical and investment cases for mass transit. This includes looking at options for early deliverables.

Question 21 – Suzanne Audrey

YTL and others keep announcing in press releases and on social media that the YTL arena will have a capacity of 20,000. The current planning permission is for events of no greater than 17,000. Please will you confirm if it is acceptable for YTL and/or WECA to keep announcing that the arena has a 20,000 capacity when YTL has not sought planning permission for this larger capacity?

Mayor's Response

We continue to support YTL's work to deliver a 20,000-capacity arena, beyond the existing planning consent, subject to the usual processes. People around the West of England have welcomed progress to transform the historic hangars ahead of the opening of the Aviva Arena at YTL Live.

A new train station, Bristol Brabazon, will open this Autumn to serve the area, at the heart of the emerging Brabazon and West Innovation Arc new town. This new station is one of five due to open in the coming years across the West, adding to the two already delivered.

Question 22 – Suzanne Audrey

The current transport plan for the YTL arena is for events with a total capacity no greater than 17,000. When will YTL be required to provide a new transport plan to WECA, and/or its constituent local authorities, if the capacity of the arena is increased to 20,000?

Mayor's Response

Bristol City Council are the local planning authority covering this site. Any application would be submitted to them to consider in the appropriate way.

Question 23 – Danica Priest

With a recommendation on today's agenda to allocate £5 million to a new Nature Recovery Fund, alongside updates on the Combined Authority's strategic partnership with Homes England, the public needs to know which of these two competing priorities takes precedence when they collide. It would be entirely contradictory to invest millions in nature recovery while simultaneously allowing a strategic housing partner to destroy an existing, irreplaceable wildlife asset. In light of these agenda items, this question is for Mayor Helen Godwin and Deputy Mayor Tony Dyer to answer individually. It requires a simple 'yes or no' answer to the following questions from both separately:

Local MP Kerry McCarthy and many Labour and Green Councillors have recently made public comments opposing Homes England and Keepmoat's plans to build over Brislington Meadows, a designated site of nature conservation interest with rare protected species like Barbastelle bats that was taken out of the new Bristol local plan.

Do you personally agree with them that Brislington Meadows SNCI should be saved for nature and protected from development?

Mayor's Response

Nature is one of the things that makes the West of England so special, so I appreciate why you are raising this issue today. Nature is a thread running through our Growth Strategy and will also be an important part of our developing Spatial Development Strategy. Growth and nature do not need to conflict, something that we know and believe in the fastest-growing regional economy, which is also the natural home of new green jobs, and the country's first new national forest in decades.

Our new £5 million Nature Fund can make a significant difference at landscape-scale projects across the region already identified through our Local Nature Recovery Strategy. The importance of this work will be underlined in next week's State of Nature report.

This site is a matter for Bristol City Council, as the local planning authority, and Homes England, as the landowner. I sympathise with the concerns of residents and appreciate the work of Kerry McCarthy MP and local councillors.

Question 24 – Danica Priest

Do you support the residents campaign to save this site?

Mayor's Response

As set out in my previous answer, I sympathise with the concerns of residents and appreciate the work of Kerry McCarthy MP and local councillors.

Question 25 – Satyen Joshi

When business cases for large transport projects are presented to WECA , is there an analysis undertaken by the combined authority to assess/audit how the collection and interpretation of data eg. traffic surveys has been undertaken by the local council presenting such business cases?

Mayor's Response

Business case bids submitted to the combined authority are assessed with a review of the way in which relevant data has been collected/used to support the bid. This review can include reference to other wider datasets.

Question 26 – Satyen Joshi

Does WECA reject business cases on Transport brought forward by local councils, where there is clear evidence that the results of an underlying public consultation for relevant business case, have been ignored?

Mayor's Response

Further to my previous answers about projects such as South Bristol Liveable Neighbourhoods, feedback from residents, including how initial proposals have been adapted based on this, will be a key part of how the combined authority assesses bids for funding. As I have said before, it's important that local people's voices are heard.

Question 27 – Jackie Head

Public Contracts Regulations 2015 compliance:

What specific steps did WECA take during the recent tendering process for the supported bus services, to demonstrate compliance with the Public Contracts Regulations 2015, and were the Overview and Scrutiny Committee provided with the full specification, scoring matrix, evaluation notes, and clarification logs so that members could assess whether the process was transparent, proportionate and nondiscriminatory?

Mayor's Response

It's important that residents in rural areas can depend on buses to get around and access everything our region has to offer. Last year, we announced a three-year funding settlement that will enable us to deliver longer term plans for bus services in our region, including connecting communities in more rural areas.

I am unfortunately unable to comment further about the tendering until that process has concluded. In the meantime, the relevant officers advise that:

"The recent tender for Supported Bus Services has been conducted in accordance with internal governance, Contract Standing Orders and Public Contracts Regulations 2015. The procurement exercise is being conducted through the combined authority's Dynamic Purchasing System (DPS) for the delivery of Supported Bus Services with the opportunity advertised to all suppliers admitted to the DPS in line with its rules. Tenders will be evaluated in accordance with the criteria set out in the procurement documentation."

Question 28 – Jackie Head

Public Sector Equality Duty evidence:

What analysis has WECA undertaken under the Public Sector Equality Duty to assess the impact of removing the only fixed route service (X91) from 10 stops across 4 villages in the Chew Valley, and how does the Equality Impact Assessment demonstrate that the needs of older residents, disabled passengers, and low income households were considered in the redesign?

Mayor's Response

It's important that residents in rural areas can depend on buses to get around and access everything our region has to offer. Last year, we announced a three-year funding settlement that will enable us to deliver longer term plans for bus services in our region, including connecting communities in more rural areas.

I understand that officers provided the following information at Monday's committee meeting about the tendering process and am unfortunately unable to comment further until that process has concluded, other than to note that any changes to bus services would need to be assessed through an Equalities Impact Assessment to consider the impacts on people with protected characteristics:

"Funding for eight services piloted under the WESTlocal scheme was due to end in April, but were extended to July to enable service provision to be reviewed, options to be considered, and a full competitive tender to be completed. We are now undergoing that procurement exercise, which is a commercially confidential process until its conclusion."

While the authority and I were/are unable to answer some questions on Monday and today, I have asked the relevant officers to collate and review the points raised to help shape future engagement around tendering.

Question 29 – Amber Eastman

In regard to the LTN in general, how is 'success' defined and which specific metrics are being used to measure it accurately?

Mayor's Response

In general, I would expect success for any project to be judged using the objectives set out in the relevant business case – alongside residents' feedback about the impact.

Question 30 – Amber Eastman

From the point of LTN implementation, if business impact data shows a sustained decline in the local economy, particularly with businesses along North St,

what formal post-implementation mechanism exists to amend or remove the scheme, and if such a mechanism exists, what timeframe would that process take?

Mayor's Response

The combined authority would expect any business case bid to set out appropriate monitoring and evaluation arrangements, including how a proposed project's intended outcomes and benefits would be judged.

For any proposed project, following a robust assessment including public feedback, amending or reviewing the scheme after it has been implemented would be a matter for

the local council as the highway authority – including considering economic impacts for local businesses.

Question 31 – David Redgewell

In other mayoral combined transport Authority such as Liverpool City Region mayor Steve Rotherham and North East mayoral combined transport Authority Kim mc Guinness and in Devon and Cornwall invest is made in Ferry services as part of the public Transport Network.

What discussion has the mayor Helen Goodwin and the west of England mayoral combined Authority North Somerset council and Bristol city council had regarding the Ferry services in Bristol Harbour and The water Taxis service between Bath spa city centre and Bathampton canal.

Including accessible ferry services and Electricitification of the ferry boat services and the provision of full accessible landing stages at Bristol Temple meads station/ Temple Quay and university buildings and around Bristol Harbour landing stages and the cross Harbour ferry services.

New ferry stop signs and shelters.

Interchange in and around the Harbour with First group plc Greater Western trains company limited GWR metro west railway Network Arriva Cross country trains 1sq capital services at Bristol Temple meads station First group plc South west buses and stagecoach Red and white and Falcon bus services. around Harbourside and in Bath .

Will the mayor Helen Goodwin and public transport team please meet with the Ferry services.

Mayor's Response

Our waterways are an important part of life in Bristol and across the West, and we value their significance for not just residents' wellbeing and nature, but as potential avenues for sustainable transportation. There are several great independent businesses that are working on our waterways, and I am keen to explore with them how we can get more people travelling by ferry.

Bristol City Council have responsibility for managing Bristol Harbour and the relevant commercial passenger operators, which is set out in the Bristol Harbour Strategy 2026-31. The Strategy sets out a number of initiatives to improve infrastructure on and adjacent to the Harbour, including access ramps and amenities to make travelling on the waterways as accessible as possible.

As with any mode of transport in our region, we really value equality, inclusion and accessibility.

Question 32 – David Redgewell

Following the west of England mayoral combined Authority and North Somerset council scrutiny commission meeting on 1st of June 2026

Main passengers groups stakeholders were very very concerned about the lack of progress and discussion on the Tendered bus Network from 26 th July 2026 and from 1st of September 2026

As their was very limited public and passengers groups and stakeholders consultation but for [***name redacted***] efforts to talk to everyone is fully acknowledged

Their is still a lot of worried community's from Wotton under Edge Charfield Wickwar chipping Sodbury Yate, y8

To Chew valley Chew stoke to Bristol city centre x91 .

Chew valley local 99

K1 Keynsham Town service.

P1 Bristol city centre to Winsford.

534 Filton to East Bristol.

40 Avonmouth to Lawrence weston Henbury and cribbs causeway bus station.

2v Bath spa Park and ride to Timsbury Paulton Midsomer Norton westfield Radstock.

522 Bristol bus and coach station to Arnos vale Bristlington keynsham Timsbury Paulton Midsomer Norton westfield Radstock Peasdown st john Bath spa bus and coach station.

Y2C Cribbs causeway bus station Bristol zoo Olverton Alverston Thornbury Tytherington and yate bus station.

768 Bath spa city centre to Cameron and Radstock.

50 Bristol city centre to oid Market Bristol Stapleton road Station Eastville park Stapleton village Blackberry Hill Fishponds Services or Begbrook and Frenchay.

Service 19 Bath spa bus and coach station to weston Kelston Swinford Bitton oidland Common Warmley Kingswood Staple Hill Downend Bromley Heath Frenchay Stapleton Stoke park uwe bus and coach station. and Bristol Parkway.

Lack of Evenings services

25 Bristol city centre, Broadmead shopping centre Haymarket, st Paul's st werburges Eastville park Fishponds Services.

Which is competition with First group bus services up the Fishponds Road .

Many Communitys are very concerned about the lack of information on the bus service from 26 July 2026 .

X10 Southmead hospital bus station Cribbs causeway bus station, Portishead Clevedon via Dial Hill Yatton Railway station to Wrington.

To work school College university heath provision Hospitals basic food shopping and connectivity to railway stations and coach interchanges and services and bus interchanges for Tourist.

Their has been no bus forums other than in North Somerset council area on 12 th June 2026 .

Or consultation on line or in booklets in libraries council offices on the supported bus network.

When will the Tendered bus Network details be made public with routes and timetables information.

Somerset unitary Council, Wiltshire Council and Gloucestershire County council hold regular bus and stakeholders forums when will this happen in the west of England mayoral combined transport Authority and North Somerset council in line with Department for Transport funding policy and requirements for passengers and stakeholders input including the NHS facilities university and colleges school and the bussiness community and passengers groups bus coach and railway operators for intergration

Westlink Demand responsive bus services With its Spanish call centre is not a replacement for the west of England and North Somerset city Region bus network that passengers and stakeholders support.

Mayor's Response

It's important that residents in rural areas can depend on buses to get around and access everything our region has to offer, and I know how important these services are to residents. Last year, we announced a three-year funding settlement that will enable us to deliver longer term plans for bus services in our region, including connecting communities in more rural areas.

Engaging with community groups will continue to be a key part of how we manage and deliver our bus services, especially in periods where things are subject to change. Once

a decision has been made then the relevant community groups will be among the very first to know. People will be able to access all the information that they need to get around.

I understand that officers provided the following information at Monday's committee meeting about the tendering process and am unfortunately unable to comment further until that process has concluded:

"Funding for eight services piloted under the WESTlocal scheme was due to end in April, but were extended to July to enable service provision to be reviewed, options to be considered, and a full competitive tender to be completed. We are now undergoing that procurement exercise, which is a commercially confidential process until its conclusion."

Question 33 – Phil Collins

Part of the purpose of the WESTlocal scheme was to gather an evidence base for needed and wanted services. What evidence can WECA provide to show how community generated data from WESTlocal in the Chew Valley (including the 'Great Big Bus

Survey' and 'The Future of Local Bus Services: What Chew Valley Wants' reports) were given to the consultant, incorporated into route design, tender evaluation, and officer recommendations?

Mayor's Response

It's important that residents in rural areas can depend on buses to get around and access everything our region has to offer, and I know how important these services are to residents. Last year, we announced a three-year funding settlement that will enable us to deliver longer term plans for bus services in our region, including connecting communities in more rural areas.

I understand that officers provided the following information at Monday's committee meeting about the tendering process and am unfortunately unable to comment further until that process has concluded, other than to say that the survey data was provided to the consultant. I am advised that the report mentioned had not been published in time to be provided to them, but that it has been taken into account by officers subsequently.

"Funding for eight services piloted under the WESTlocal scheme was due to end in April, but were extended to July to enable service provision to be reviewed, options to be considered, and a full competitive tender to be completed. We are now undergoing that procurement exercise, which is a commercially confidential process until its conclusion."

Question 34 – Phil Collins

Impact of removing direct access:

What modelling has WECA carried out

to quantify the impact of removing direct access to Bristol for 10 stops across

4 villages, (via the X91) and how does this modelling show compliance with the National Bus Strategy requirement to improve rural connectivity rather than reduce it?

Mayor's Response

It's important that residents in rural areas can depend on buses to get around and access everything our region has to offer. Last year, we announced a three-year funding settlement that will enable us to deliver longer term plans for bus services in our region, including connecting communities in more rural areas.

I understand that officers provided the following information at Monday's committee meeting and am unfortunately unable to comment further until that process has concluded.

"Funding for eight services piloted under the WESTlocal scheme was due to end in April, but were extended to July to enable service provision to be reviewed, options to be considered, and a full competitive tender to be completed. We are now undergoing that procurement exercise, which is a commercially confidential process until its conclusion."

While the authority and I were/are unable to answer some questions on Monday and today, I have asked the relevant officers to collate and review the points raised to help shape future engagement around tendering.

Question 35 – Elaine Workman

Best Value Duty justification:

What evidence can WECA provide to show

that replacing a direct, single vehicle route (X91) with a WESTlink plus interchange model (with no guaranteed connection) delivers Best Value in terms of economy, efficiency, effectiveness, and social value?

Mayor's Response

It's important that residents in rural areas can depend on buses to get around and access everything our region has to offer. Last year, we announced a three-year funding settlement that will enable us to deliver longer term plans for bus services in our region, including connecting communities in more rural areas.

I understand that officers provided the following information at Monday's committee meeting and am unfortunately unable to comment further until that process has concluded.

"Funding for eight services piloted under the WESTlocal scheme was due to end in April, but were extended to July to enable service provision to be reviewed, options to be considered, and a full competitive tender to be completed. We are now undergoing that procurement exercise, which is a commercially confidential process until its conclusion."

While the authority and I were/are unable to answer some questions on Monday and today, I have asked the relevant officers to collate and review the points raised to help shape future engagement around tendering.

Question 36 – Elaine Workman

Rural Proofing assessment:

How has WECA applied DEFRA's Rural

Proofing Guidance to assess the consequences of withdrawing direct bus access to Bristol (via the X91) for four rural villages, and what mitigation measures were considered or rejected?

Mayor's Response

It's important that residents in rural areas can depend on buses to get around and access everything our region has to offer. Last year, we announced a three-year funding settlement that will enable us to deliver longer term plans for bus services in our region, including connecting communities in more rural areas.

I understand that officers provided the following information at Monday's committee meeting and am unfortunately unable to comment further until that process has concluded, but can confirm that the combined authority's processes take into account the principles of the guidance that you mention.

"Funding for eight services piloted under the WESTlocal scheme was due to end in April, but were extended to July to enable service provision to be reviewed, options to be considered, and a full competitive tender to be completed. We are now undergoing that procurement exercise, which is a commercially confidential process until its conclusion."

While the authority and I were/are unable to answer some questions on Monday and today, I have asked the relevant officers to collate and review the points raised to help shape future engagement around tendering.

Question 37 – Jo Sergeant

Ahead of last Monday's Overview & Scrutiny Committee, my colleague submitted the following question, included in that meeting's Public Forum pack:

In the recent Draft Local Transport Delivery Plan, WECA announced proposed allocations from the recent Government grant of the following:

£150 million for bus improvements

£150 million for rail

£150 million for mass transit

£50 million for active travel

As it is highly unlikely that this money will even scratch the surface of any capital projects, what is the basis for these allocations?

She received the following Officer response:

As set out in March's committee report, the Transport for City Regions (TCR) programme will focus investment on transport improvements that address strategic constraints and support growth, developing interventions aligned to adopted and emerging spatial and economic strategies.

Last year, more than three quarters of a billion pounds was secured for transport from government: a record for the West of England. We are working hard to position our region well for even greater funding settlements in future national Spending Reviews, alongside our wider work to secure more investment for the region.

It is hard to find anything in this response that addresses the question so I will rephrase it:

What are the identified costs that have amounted, at this stage, to approximately £150 million each for bus improvements, rail and mass transit, in addition to the £50 million being set aside for active travel?

Mayor's Response

At the last committee meeting, the draft Local Transport Delivery Plan (LTDP) proposed strategic allocations across the key modes of bus, rail, mass transit, and active travel.

This reflects our overall transport priorities for the region. A proportionate approach was taken in that paper, so these allocations were deliberately outline in nature and they will naturally be subject to refinement. We expect more detail to be confirmed in the next submission of the LTDP.

The combined authority is committed to taking a long-term view of transport investment, including maintaining a pipeline of deliverable and strategically important schemes. This will mean that some schemes may be developed during the current funding period for delivery under a future funding settlement, as we continue to make the case for greater investment on top of the unprecedented sums already secured.

Question 38 – Jo Sergeant

The reply to my question (submitted earlier this year) about the Enhanced Partnership model for regional bus operations referred to ‘performance measures’, that would ‘ensure partners are accountable’.

What sort of measures could be put in place to ensure that operators don’t just prioritise the most profitable routes, to the detriment of services with fewer passenger numbers, which are already less frequent and less reliable?

Mayor’s Response

A performance framework will be developed through the review of the Enhanced Partnership and will be agreed between all partners. A performance framework can include a variety of different measures to ensure that the network is monitored effectively and fairly. Measures can include punctuality, reliability, patronage, customer satisfaction as well as social value and accessibility.

While we await final government guidance on socially necessary bus routes, we are already beginning to look at then network as a whole and consider how we can work with operators to provide those socially necessary services.

It is essential that the whole network is monitored, and I have asked the relevant officers to take the necessary steps to do so effectively.

Question 39 – Cllr Christine Townsend

Nationally 6% (known to social care) are in paid employment of adults with learning difficulties and/or autism are in paid employment.

Locally We Work for Everyone is an established and evidentially successful into work programme focusing on this group of residents –this programme offers 12 months of personalised support with participants moving into paid work. Bristol is the lead LA in the WECA region, as of today the funding for this programme will end on March 31st 2027.

How does this strategy ensure the knowledge, expertise and staff teams are retained after March '27 and that participants in the coming 10 months will experience the cohesive and individualised service that meet their needs?

Mayor's Response

Funding for the WE Work for Everyone programme runs until March 2027. The programme will be managed to ensure that participants already currently on programme are supported to transition into paid work. No new referrals will be taken on where support cannot conclude within the project lifetime. The relevant officers will ensure key stakeholders are well informed and supported to engage with alternative projects and to enable learning from evaluation to be embedded in other relevant projects such as Connect to Work.

There are two routes to supporting the current WE Work participants (specifically those with learning difficulties and autism): Connect to Work is a new four-year programme (funded by DWP) which supports Disabled people and people with health barriers to move into work or to remain in work. WorkWell, managed by the Integrated Care Board and administered the city council, supports those are referred through a healthcare setting with employment support via a network of coaches who can work with residents.

Question 40 – Cllr Christine Townsend

How will the DWP's Connect to Work programme ensure that the specific needs of this cohort are understood and that they are not disproportionately disadvantaged due to the nature of the Connect to Work delivery model, their needs are met and that the learning and expertise of the last seven years across the WECA region is retained and built upon?

Mayor's Response

Further to my previous answer, the relevant officers advise that when all Employment Support coaches have been recruited through Connect to Work then an audit will be undertaken to understand staffing specialisms, referral routes, and existing networks. Alongside our data, this will help identify both strengths and gaps in support for the variety of target groups who we need to deliver for. If there are gaps, then we can look to

actively recruit specialists when there is more funding. We also have some flexible funding available to procure specialist services if required.

Question 41 – Caroline Dunn

Is WECA funding Bristol women's Voice

Mayor's Response

I know that the combined authority funds the West of England Women's Commission. This body was preceded by the Bristol Women's Commission, which is a separate organisation from Bristol Women's Voice.

The transparency section of the combined authority's website sets out further details about transactions and funding.

Question 42 – Caroline Dunn

Will the mayor start a group of disabled people to help with decisions about transport etc.

Mayor's Response

As part of the Enhanced Partnership review, we are considering how best to strengthen engagement between passengers, including Disabled people; bus operators; and the combined authority. We want to ensure that any structures reflect a broad cross-section of our communities, including representation from different geographic areas, age groups, backgrounds and passenger needs.

We are committed to promoting equality, inclusion and accessibility across the region's transport network. We recognise the importance of ensuring that all passengers are treated with dignity and respect and that transport services are accessible and welcoming to everyone. Through the area-wide Enhanced Partnership, bus operators in the area have committed to ensuring that bus drivers are trained in disability awareness as part of the Bus Passenger Charter.